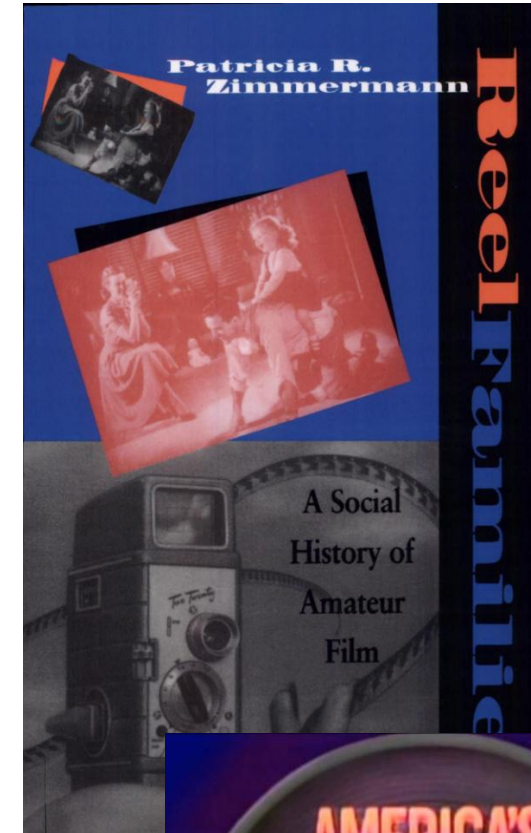
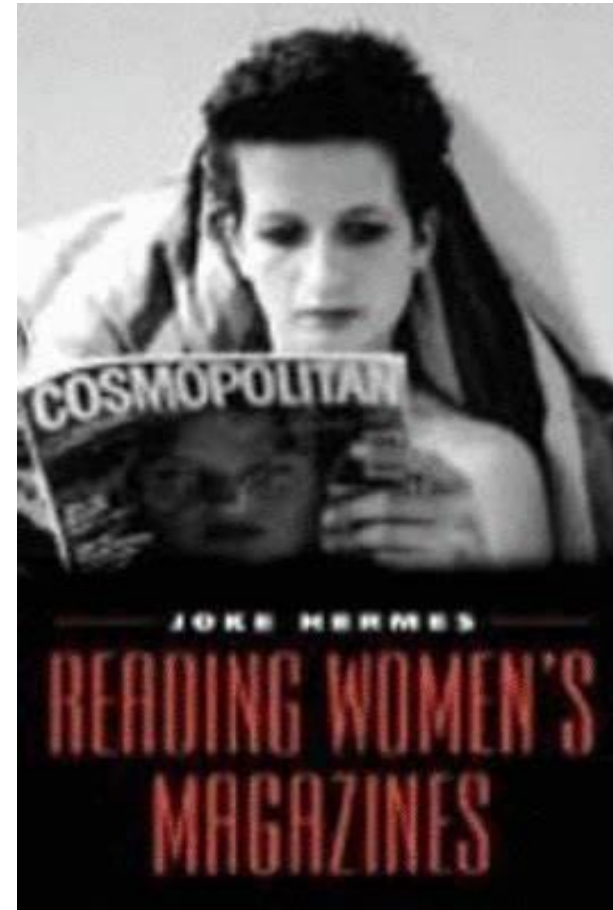
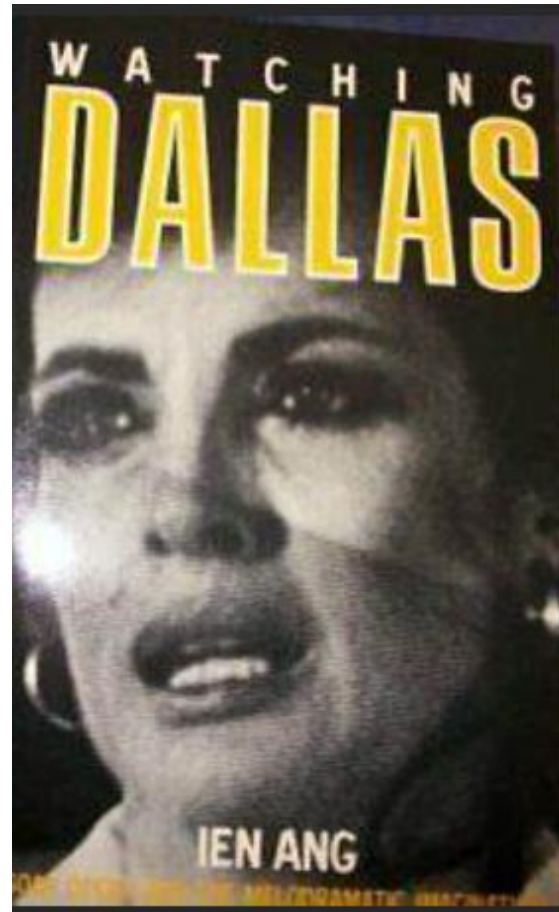


Locating the popular pleasures of TikTok historically

Vine





(1) Identification and emotional realism on TikTok

- “Being on TikTok is like seeing what your friends are up to if your friends were all kind of cool and you didn’t have any obligation towards them” (Judith).
- Similarities to popular pleasures of identification and emotional realism that Ien Ang (1985) found among soap opera audiences.
- TikTok algorithm creates textual structure of everyday life as ‘I’ know it yet as readily enjoyable entertainment.

(2) Ontological security through TikTok routines

- Popular genres / tv inducing sense of ontological security in daily life (e.g. Morley 1986, Silverstone 1994; concept Giddens 1991).
- Television as an opportunity to structure the experiential fabric of the everyday, negotiation self-other relationality.
- TikTok similar role for young adults, turning to app when wanting to 'escape' here and now and experience more stable emotions.

(3) Putdownability and TikTok's flexible structure

- Key element of magazines them being 'putdownable', flexible terms of when and how to be used meaningfully in day (Hermes 1995).
- TikTok, as a mobile phone app, corresponds to this flexibility, contrasting linearity of tv shows and broadcasting schedules in historical comparison.
- Flexible design also enacting an 'addictive design', turning responsibility for putting the phone down on the user alone.

Popular culture: contradictory and continuous

- TikTok is part of a long lineage of popular media that have afforded pleasure for different generations.
- TikTok not free from problems (e.g. addictive design, privacy implications, ...). Yet also problem in not focussing on how users deal with the app, including and going beyond problems.
- Thinking historically about TikTok doesn't help understand its newness (e.g. algorithm) but serves as crucial reminder for the ways in which we qualify the meaning of 'guilty pleasures' like it.

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